## Why has the crisis become visible?

In effect, the refugee crisis has become an annual event, especially since the 2012 violence, and happens in the May–July period, when the Andaman Sea is calm enough to allow safe passage.[99] It is fuelled by the utter desperation of people in Myanmar (and to a lesser extent in Bangladesh) and feeds into economies increasingly based on slave labour—or, at best, illegal and undocumented labour. Along the way, criminal gangs make substantial profits. The only real difference in 2015 was that the Malaysian and Indonesian governments closed their borders—in contravention of the UN Charter, but emulating the response of some European governments to the refugee crisis in the Mediterranean. Traditionally, boats would be abandoned by the traffickers close to the shore and people were expected to find their own way ashore, often helped by local fishermen. This year, when boats came close to the land they were pushed back out to sea by the local authorities.[100] However, by this point in the journey the trafficker crews were long gone, thus leaving those on board with no food and at the mercy of the sea.

In previous years all this had happened out of sight of the world's media. But in 2015 the sheer scale of the crisis and the response by Malaysia and Indonesia made it all too visible. Early coverage made no link to the situation in Myanmar and treated it as though these were migrants simply moving from one country to another in search of work. Fortunately, connections were eventually made.[101] In part, this was because of reporters' ignorance of the Rohingyas' situation, but it also reflects the success of the Myanmar regime in bullying independent organisations to the extent that some never even use the name 'Rohingyas', and never make an explicit link between their plight and Myanmar state policy.[102]

## The response of the Myanmar regime

The regime has responded in a variety of ways to the migrant crisis, many of them depressingly predictable. To begin with, it refused to attend a regional ASEAN summit called to discuss the crisis.[103] When it finally relented, the authorities agreed to attend the Bangkok meeting only after being assured that the term 'Rohingya' would not be used. It was agreed